



Long wait ends: East Bengal players savour a historic moment after clinching the Indian Super League crown. AIFF MEDIA

History's debt repaid

East Bengal ended a 22-year league title drought, overcoming years of decline and frustration to **reclaim** its place among Indian football's elite.

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It felt like liberation from "footballing purgatory" for East Bengal FC when the club defeated Inter Kashi FC on the evening of May 21 to win the Indian Super League (ISL) crown. Scores of supporters, young and old alike, were seen shedding tears of joy in the stands of Kishore

Bharati Stadium. The venue glowed under red-and-yellow flares as more than two decades of heartbreak, underachievement and decline seemed to lift from the club and its supporters.

For East Bengal supporters, the triumph ended a painful 22-year wait for the country's top-flight league

title, their last league triumph having come in 2004 when the club successfully defended the National Football League crown.

What followed was a prolonged period of frustration as East Bengal repeatedly failed to reclaim national supremacy while Indian football changed around it. The National